

Crime Type: Cyberbullying

Scenario: Cyberbullying happens when a student named "A" becomes the target of consistent online harassment after a minor disagreement in a student WhatsApp group. The crime typically happens step-by-step: it begins with exclusionary behaviour, followed by the creation of "troll" accounts on Instagram that post manipulated photos of the victim with derogatory captions. The perpetrators then spam the victim's private messages with threats and encourage others to post hateful comments under the victim's academic achievements.

Target and Methodology: College students are usually targeted because of their high level of digital engagement and the social pressure to remain active on messaging apps. Perpetrators often feel a sense of "online disinhibition," believing that the distance provided by a screen protects them from consequences. They use tools like anonymous confession pages or ephemeral messaging (like Snapchat) to spread rumours quickly.

Consequences: The consequences of cyberbullying are severe and multi-layered. For the victim, it often leads to extreme anxiety, social withdrawal, and a significant drop in academic performance. In some cases, it can lead to long-term psychological trauma. For the perpetrators, if reported, the consequences include suspension or expulsion under university IT policies and potential legal action under Section 66A of the IT Act (where applicable) and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.